

HAVENBAY PROCESS RULINGS — REQUESTED

Date: 2026-08-25 · **For:** Stephen · **Status:** AWAITING RULING, one line each

What you are ruling, and what you are not

You are setting parameters, not granting powers.

A **parameter** is how long a harbour authority keeps its logs, or whether a family can ask a laboratory for its handling records. That is worldbuilding. You have already done it twice: the 150-second energy regen, and the all-party consent rule.

A **power** is a contractor overriding a coroner, or a forged form defeating a custody check. Kill Gate Zero exists to stop that, and none of these rulings touches it.

The test is not "is this the law somewhere." Havenbay is fictional. The test is **would an ordinary player believe an institution behaves this way**, and would it stay consistent across a season. Every recommendation below is set at what institutions commonly do, so nothing reads as convenient.

Some of these rulings kill stories rather than saving them, and I have marked those. A ruling list that only unlocked things would be a wish list.

TIER ONE — rulings that unlock premises already killed

R1. How long are sample handling records kept, as distinct from the samples themselves?

Recommended: samples destroyed on a defined schedule, but the record of who handled them is kept for twenty-five years and is disclosable to next of kin.

Why it reads true: records almost always outlive the material they describe, because a register is cheap to keep and a freezer is not. Every player who has ever chased a receipt for a thing they no longer own understands this instantly.

Unlocks: my N3, where the toxicology is correctly destroyed and the custody record survives. Without this ruling the premise has no evidence at all.

R2. Are weather and visibility observations a permanent public record?

Recommended: yes. The meteorological service keeps observations permanently and they are publicly searchable.

Why it reads true: weather archives genuinely are permanent and public, and players have looked up old weather themselves.

Unlocks: my C2, where an identification made in fog is contradicted by the record of that evening. Currently marked unverified.

R3. Are harbour authority contracts and payments a public register?

Recommended: yes. A public body's contracts and payments are published and searchable, retained seven years.

Why it reads true: public money is published. This is one of the few things the average person expects to be able to look up.

Unlocks: my F3, where a yard bills the authority for work it never did.

R4. What happens to a company's records when it is wound up?

Recommended: they pass to the liquidator, then to whichever entity buys the assets, and must be retained seven years after dissolution. Nothing is destroyed during that window.

Why it reads true: this is how business failure actually works, and it explains why old paperwork turns up in odd places.

Unlocks: Slack Water's ferry-office paperwork surviving into an archive. Also creates a **season hook**: somebody buying failed companies' *records* rather than their assets is a Ferryman-shaped fact.

R5. Can next of kin obtain coronial findings and the evidence tendered?

Recommended: yes to findings and tendered evidence. No to police running sheets, working notes, or unused material.

Why it reads true: it draws the line where families actually find it — you get the conclusion and what was shown, not the investigators' notebooks.

Unlocks: confirms the access route several premises across both fields already use, which are currently unverified rather than wrong.

R6. Can inquest and court transcripts be ordered by anyone?

Recommended: yes, on payment of a fee. Proceedings are public unless restricted.

Why it reads true: open justice is a principle most players already assume.

Unlocks: confirms an access route used in four premises across both fields.

TIER TWO — rulings that prevent the next round of deaths

R7. How long is CCTV kept?

Recommended: thirty-one days, and indefinitely once flagged for an investigation.

Why it reads true: this is the real and near-universal figure, and the thirty-one-day cliff is inherently dramatic.

R8. How long is ordinary commercial operational data kept — dispatch, tracking, transactions?

Recommended: seven years, matching business record-keeping norms.

Why it reads true: seven years is the number small businesses actually live by.

△ *This kills rather than saves.* It confirms that a taxi dispatch record from 2001 does not exist, so that premise stays dead. **Seven years is the honest number and twenty-five would be a convenience.**

R9. Who owns an investigation report commissioned by an insurer?

Recommended: the insurer owns it. Where it was prepared in contemplation of a claim dispute it is privileged, and the investigator who wrote it may not release it unilaterally.

Why it reads true: people understand that work you pay for belongs to you.

△ *This kills rather than saves.* It removes the access route in my own N1, where a retired investigator hands over the insurer's unfiled report. **That premise needs a different route or it fails.** I would rather lose it than rule the convenient way.

R10. Can next of kin obtain a deceased person's medical records?

Recommended: yes, for next of kin or an executor, with third-party information redacted. Not obtainable by anyone else, and never by a podcaster in her own right.

Why it reads true: families do get these, and the redaction is the part that feels institutional rather than magical.

R11. Who can obtain a death certificate, and when does one become public?

Recommended: restricted to next of kin, executors and legal representatives for thirty years, then open to public search.

Why it reads true: it matches how registries handle recent versus historical records.

△ *Partly kills*. My N2 assumed two death certificates were freely searchable. Under this ruling the 2009 one is open and the 2020 one is not, so that premise needs its access rebuilt around the family rather than the register.

R12. How long are fire investigation reports kept and who can see them?

Recommended: retained twenty years. Findings supplied to the coroner, the property owner and the insurer. Working notes are not disclosable.

Why it reads true: the split between a filed finding and an investigator's notebook is the same line as R5, which keeps the world consistent.

R13. What does a workplace fatality investigation produce, and for whom?

Recommended: the regulator investigates, the site is preserved until released, and the report goes to next of kin and to the coroner.

Why it reads true: it is what actually happens, and it puts a real obstacle in front of anyone who wants to tamper with a scene.

R14. Are council permits, planning records and property transfers publicly searchable?

Recommended: yes, all three, permanently.

Why it reads true: people search property records for fun. It is one of the most credible research activities you can give a player.

R15. Who can access vehicle event data?

Recommended: it belongs to the vehicle owner; an insurer may hold a copy under the policy; police seizure removes all other access.

△ *Kills*. Confirms that a family cannot reach event data on a seized vehicle, so that premise stays dead unless the family owns the car.

What this changes

	Count
Premises unlocked that were previously dead or unverified	4 — N3, C2, F3, Slack Water's archive route
Access routes confirmed that were unverified rather than wrong	several across both fields
Premises honestly killed or requiring rebuild	4 — the taxi dispatch seed, my N1, my N2, the vehicle data seed
Future seeds that will no longer die on UNKNOWN	all those depending on R5 to R15

The scoreboard matters more than the unlocks. Four saved and four killed is what an honest ruling set looks like. If every ruling had gone my way, the list would be a wish list wearing a uniform.

How to rule

Mark each **YES**, **NO**, or **AMEND with your number**. Where you amend, only the value changes — the shape of the rule stays.

Once ruled, they become canon in the bible under a new section, both models generate against them, and any seed that previously died for want of that ruling may be resubmitted **once**, under the normal gates.

One caution. These become permanent. A retention period ruled generously today makes every future evidence problem easier and every future episode slightly less credible. Where I have recommended a short or inconvenient number — R8's seven years especially — it is because the constraint is what makes the world feel real, and because a player who has ever been told "sorry, we only keep those for seven years" will recognise it immediately.